STATE SCAN

ASSAM: EARLY WARNING FAILURE *PG 30*

MP: E20 TWIST, RICE ON A ROUND TRIP *PG 32*



A LIFELINE Uddhav, Raj Thackeray and others join the students' protest, Mumbai, June 26

ANI

▶ MAHARASHTRA

GEN Z GLOSS FOR BRAND THACKERAY

Uddhav was at the lowest ebb of his career, with a haemorrhaging party. Then the CJP moment turned the narrative. Can he cash in?

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

A CURIOUS DYNAMIC HAS TAKEN HOLD OF THE leadership space in Maharashtra all of a sudden. Disparate events over the past month have converged to stir the genie in the bottle—even if nothing changes on the surface, it masks unpredictable twists in the undercurrents. Look at a quintessential Maharashtra quartet: no element is unaffected. Chief minister Devendra Fadnavis is suddenly being spoken of as a potential export to New Delhi. Predicated on that would be deputy chief minister Eknath Shinde's wish fulfilment. One of its enabling factors, octogenarian Sharad Pawar's shift to the ruling side, has been put on a last-minute fork in the road by Gen Z! That last one has also arrived just in time to perchance give a fresh lease of life to a beleaguered Uddhav Thackeray.

On July 26, when the Shiv Sena (UBT) chief appeared on stage at Shivaji Park in Mumbai, standing in front of thousands of cheering youth, he was coming off the lowest ebb in his political